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ELECTION RESULTS ROUNDUP - Democrats Kamlager, Rivas, Gabriel lead Assembly races in early returns

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Early returns in three special elections for the California Assembly in parts of Los Angeles on Tuesday were good news for Democrats Sydney Kamlager, Luz Rivas and Jesse Gabriel.

If initial trends continued, Rivas, in the northeast San Fernando Valley, and Gabriel, in the west Valley, would advance to June 5 runoffs against Republican candidates who ran strongly in the races to replace a pair of Assembly members who resigned amid sexual-misconduct scandals.

Meanwhile, Kamlager, in a district representing a portion of L.A., Culver City and Inglewood, appeared to be on her way to winning an outright majority and avoiding a runoff in the race to replace an assemblyman who quit because of health problems.

Democratic voters outnumber Republicans by wide margins in all three districts, giving Democrats high hopes of winning runoffs against GOP candidates.

Women were in position to win two of the three races in California's first elections of the #MeToo era.

Gabriel, an attorney, had 31.1 percent, and Republican Justin Clark, a Cal State Northridge political science student, 30.4 percent in the first flash of results in Assembly District 45. Democrat Tricia Robbins Kasson was third with 15.4 percent, and independent Dennis Zine was fourth with 9.5 percent. The eventual winner will serve the remaining months of the term of Democrat Matt Dababneh, who resigned in December after multiple women accused him sexual misconduct.

Rivas, a non-profit founder, had 40.6 percent, while Republican Ricardo Benitez, who owns a contracting business, had 25.9 percent with a fraction of votes counted in Assembly District 39. Democrat Antonio Sanchez was third with 16.5 percent, Patty Lopez fourth with 9.1 percent. The winner will replace Democrat Raul Bocanegra, who also resigned late in 2017 after being accused of sexual harassment.

Kamlager, president of the L.A. Community College Board of Trustees, was on her way to being Tuesday's only outright winner. She had 64.8 percent of the votes to Republican Glen Ratcliff's 15.8 percent and Democrat Tepring Piquado's 15.5 percent with the first few precincts reporting in the four-person race in Assembly District 54. The seat is open because of the resignation of Sebastian Ridley-Thomas late last year.

In each election, the winner will serve the remaining months of a two-year term that ends Dec. 3.

The elections' importance could go beyond the fact that the winners will represent districts with populations of about 465,000 each.

These were California's first elections of a 2018 political season in which the state's voters will choose statewide leaders and could help to determine whether Democrats will take control of Congress from Republicans

And they were California's first elections since sexual-harassment allegations began to rattle the state capitol last fall after the scandal involving Hollywood mogul Harvey Weinstein drew attention to mistreatment of women by powerful men in many industries.

Analysts were watching Tuesday’s returns for clues about trends that could affect later races, including hints about the strength of women candidates and the enthusiasm of Democratic voters.

In addition to Bocanegra and Dababneh, sexual misconduct allegations forced the resignation of state Sen. Tony Mendoza of Artesia, prompted an official reprimand for state Sen. Bob Hertzberg of Van Nuys, and led to an unpaid leave pending completion of an investigation of Assemblywoman Cristina Garcia of Bell Gardens.

Calls for a change of culture in Sacramento are thought to be one reason that more women candidates than usual entered the three special elections, and women seemed likely to win at least one of the three seats, increasing women’s share of the California Legislature from the current 22 percent.

The resignations have had another effect: The vacancies have at least temporarily dropped Democrats’ share of Assembly and Senate seats below the two-thirds supermajority that would allow the state’s dominant party to pass tax legislation and emergency laws without cooperation from Republicans.

Despite all that, voter turnout for the special elections was expected to be low, with most of the votes likely to be cast by mail. In recent stand-alone special elections in L.A. County, less than 10 percent of registered voters have participated.

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